Announcements and reminders

Final exam: Monday, 27 Apr, 5pm-7pm, MPSH-2A

- You must be physically present at the venue. If you miss the exam, you'll have to apply for Special Consideration on EduRec, regardless of the reason and whether you've informed me in advance.
- Pre-assigned seating: your seat number will be available on EduRec.
- Bring your student ID.
- We'll use Examplify. If you can't bring your own laptop, please let me know.
- The exam will be open book, meaning you may bring one sheet of paper (handwritten or printed, A4 or smaller, double-sided). You won't have access to the internet or files saved on your laptop.
- Rough/draft paper will be available from the invigilators as in the midterm exam. You should bring your own pen/pencil.
- Fully charge your laptop before the exam, if possible, and bring your own charger if you'll need to charge your laptop.
- The MPSH-2A seating plan is posted in the Files section on Canvas (it might have changed, though).
- Please place your bag at the side or at the back of the exam venue.
- The exam questions will focus on Weeks 6-13 lectures and readings, but some questions will *combine* these materials with the Weeks 2-5 materials (Don't forget to study the Week 6 materials).
- There will be about 23-25 questions.
- As before, some questions may require you to know something in a reading that is not covered in lectures (except for Schneider, "The Problem of AI Consciousness" and Levinson, ""Defining Art Historically").

Announcements and reminders

Final exam: Monday, 27 Apr, 5pm-7pm, MPSH-2A

- You'll need to download the exam before the exam starts—I'll make an announcement a few days before the exam about when it will be available for download
- You are not allowed to leave the venue within the first hour and the last 15 minutes of the assessment,
- Any food, hot beverages, and sweetened drinks in takeaway cups are not permitted inside the MPSH.

Practice questions will be posted on Canvas by Monday. I'll make an announcement after posting them.

There will be special office hours for final exam preparation on Zoom, on 20 Apr (Monday) 3:00 pm - 4:30 pm. The Zoom link will be available on Canvas in the Zoom section.

Please consider submitting Student Feedback if you have the time. Your feedback is extremely valuable!

In case you want to take more philosophy courses…

Ethics: philosophy about morality, which consists of the following sub-areas

Applied ethics: specific moral issues (e.g., abortion, eating meat, donation, etc.)

PH2208/GEK2029 Applied Ethics

Normative ethics: what determines what is right or wrong (e.g., utilitarianism, Kant, etc.)

PH3230 Normative Ethical Theory

Metaethics: the nature of morality (objective or not, etc.)

PH3203 Moral Philosophy

In case you want to take more philosophy courses…

Free will → PH2213 Metaphysics (when taught by Isaac Wilhelm), PH4215 Freedom and Moral Responsibility

Religion → PH2211 Philosophy of Religion

Consciousness → PH2241 Philosophy of Mind, PH3241 Consciousness

Art → PH2209 Philosophy of Art, PH2224 Philosophy and Film, PH3214 Philosophy and Literature

Argument, validity → GEK2048/GET1026 Effective Reasoning, GEM2006/GET1028 Logic

Overview of all philosophy modules (course descriptions here are not always accurate, so make sure to check out syllabi on Canvas):
https://fass.nus.edu.sg/philo/overview-of-all-courses/

Death

royalacademy.org.uk/exhibition/helene-schjerfbeck

RA

What's on | Visit | Learn | Art & Architecture | Join & Support

Image caption

Exhibition

Helene Schjerfbeck

20 July - 27 October 2019

The Gabrielle Jungels-Winkler Galleries, Burlington Gardens, Royal Academy of Arts

Discover the mesmerising paintings of Helene Schjerfbeck, one of Finland's best kept secrets, in the UK's first major exhibition of her work.

Helene Schjerfbeck (1862–1946) is a Finnish national icon. From her early naturalistic style – honed during her studies in France – to her highly abstracted self-portraits, this exhibition will present Schjerfbeck for the first time to UK audiences.

Talented and widely travelled, Schjerfbeck found artistic success at a young age. In the 1880s she connected with artists' colonies in Pont Aven, Brittany and St. Ives, Cornwall. In her later years, she left the Finnish capital for a quieter life that allowed her to concentrate on her work.

Daily 10am – 6pm
Friday 10am – 10pm

£14 (without donation £12). Concessions available. Friends of the RA, and under 16s when with a fee-paying adult, go free.

Friends of the RA go free
Join now →

1884-85, age 22?

1895, age 33?

1912, age 50?

1915, age 53?

1934, age 72?

1939, age 77?

1944, age 82?

1945, age 83?

1945, age 83?

1884-85, age 22?

1945, age 83?

1884-85, age 22?

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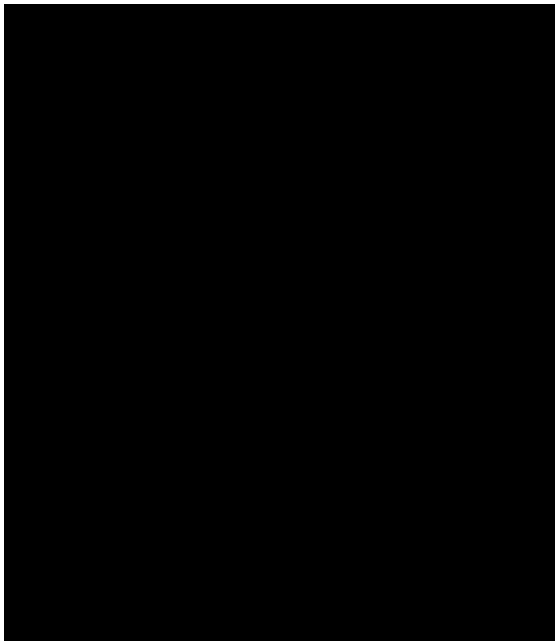


Death

Is death bad for the person who dies?

"the unequivocal and permanent end of our existence" (p.73)
"*permanent* death, unsupplemented by any form of conscious survival" (p.74)

Is death bad for the person who dies?

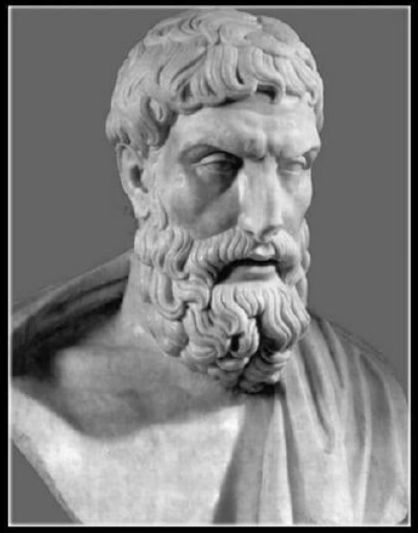
≠ the process of dying (the person still exists, may experience the process).

Is death bad for the person who dies?

as opposed to their family, friends, etc. who are alive

Is death bad for the person who dies?

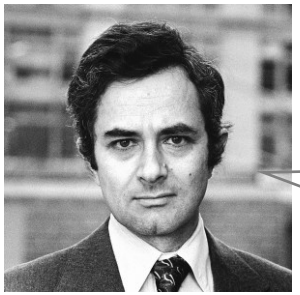
Of course, it is!



"Why should I fear death?
If I am, death is not.
If death is, I am not."

— Epicurus

Thomas Nagel, “Death” (1970)



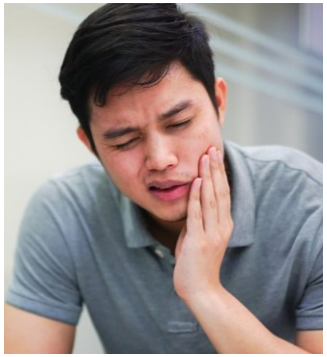
Nagel (1937-)

Death is bad for the person who dies because it deprives them of the goods that they would otherwise have had.

Nagel argues for the claim that death is bad for the person who dies by responding to three challenges.

First challenge

1. “it may be doubted that there are any evils which consist merely in the **deprivation** or **absence** of possible goods, and which do not depend on someone’s *minding* that deprivation.” (pp.75-6)



A typical example of something being bad for you, such as pain:

1. The badness consists in a “positive” feature, that is, something bad being *present*, not something good being absent.

2. You mind that thing.

1. No “positive” features that can count as bad

2. You don’t mind that thing.

First challenge

1. "it may be doubted that there are any evils which consist merely in the **deprivation** or **absence** of possible goods, and which do not depend on someone's *minding* that deprivation." (pp.75-6)

Nagel (1937-)

"Suppose an intelligent person receives a brain injury that reduces him to the mental condition of a contented infant, and that such desires as remain to him are satisfied by a custodian, so that he is free from care. Such a development would be widely regarded as a severe misfortune, not only for his friends and relations, or for society, but also, and primarily, for the person himself. This does not mean that a contented infant is unfortunate. The intelligent adult who has been reduced to this condition is the subject of the misfortune. He is the one we pity, though of course he does not mind his condition—there is some doubt, in fact, whether he can be said to exist any longer." (p.77)

1. No "positive" features that can count as bad
2. He doesn't mind his condition.

Still, what happened to him is bad for him!

First challenge

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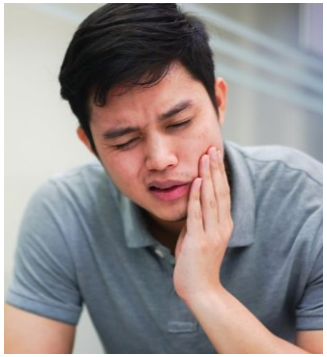

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Nagel (1937-)

1. No “positive” features that can count as bad
2. He doesn’t mind his condition.

Still, what happened to him is bad for him!

But exactly why is it bad for him??

First challenge

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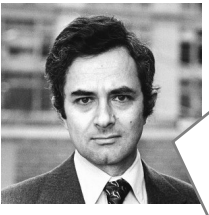


Nagel (1937-)

"If, instead of concentrating exclusively on the oversized baby before us, we consider the person he was, and **the person he could be now**, then his reduction to this state and the cancellation of his natural adult development constitute a perfectly intelligible catastrophe.

The case of mental degeneration shows us **an evil that depends on a contrast between the reality and the possible alternatives**. A man is the subject of good and evil as much because he has hopes which may or may not be fulfilled, or possibilities which may or may not be realized, as because of his capacity to suffer and enjoy. If death is an evil, it must be accounted for in these terms

When a man dies…He has lost his life, and if he had not died, he would have continued to live it, and to possess whatever good there is in living." (pp.77-78)

Second challenge

2. "there are special difficulties, in the case of death, about how the supposed misfortune is to be assigned to a subject at all. There is doubt both as to who its subject is, and as to when he undergoes it. So long as a person exists, he has not yet died, and once he has died, he no longer exists; so **there seems to be no time when death, if it is a misfortune, can be ascribed to its unfortunate subject.**" (pp.76)

P1. Death is bad for the person who dies only if there is some particular time when death is bad for the person.

P2. There is no particular time when death is bad for the person.

C. Death is not bad for the person who dies.

Valid or invalid?

(1) Always valid

A, only if B
A.
Therefore, B.

(2) Always valid

A, only if B
Not B.
Therefore, Not A.

(3) Always invalid

A, only if B
Not A.
Therefore, Not B.

(4) Always invalid

A, only if B
B.
Therefore, A.

Second challenge

2. "there are special difficulties, in the case of death, about how the supposed misfortune is to be assigned to a subject at all. There is doubt both as to who its subject is, and as to when he undergoes it. So long as a person exists, he has not yet died, and once he has died, he no longer exists; so **there seems to be no time when death, if it is a misfortune, can be ascribed to its unfortunate subject.**" (pp.76)

P1. Death is bad for the person who dies only if there is some particular time when death is bad for the person.

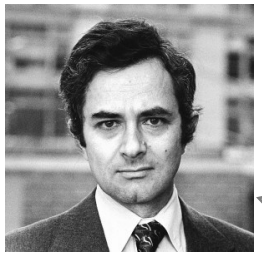
P2. There is no particular time when death is bad for the person.

C. Death is not bad for the person who dies.

Which premise should we reject if we don't want to accept the conclusion?

Second challenge

2. “there are special difficulties, in the case of death, about how the supposed misfortune is to be assigned to a subject at all. There is doubt both as to who its subject is, and as to when he undergoes it. So long as a person exists, he has not yet died, and once he has died, he no longer exists; so **there seems to be no time when death, if it is a misfortune, can be ascribed to its unfortunate subject.**” (pp.76)



Nagel (1937-)

“while this subject can be exactly located in a sequence of places and times, the same is not necessarily true of the goods and ills that befall him.

although the spatial and temporal locations of the individual who suffered the loss are clear enough, the misfortune itself cannot be so easily located.” (pp.77-78)

Elsewhere, he points out that Abraham Lincoln (1809-1865, 1.93m?) was taller than Louis XIV (1638-1715, 1.62m?) although we can’t say when.

Second challenge

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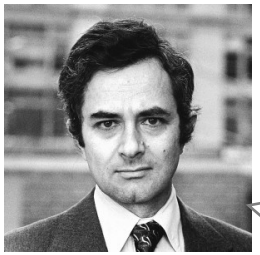


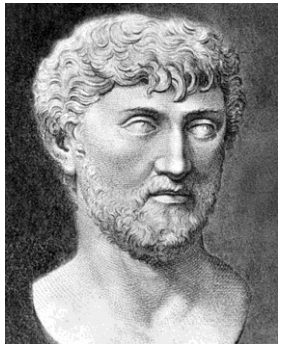
Nagel (1937-)

This doesn't mean that nonexistence is bad for someone who has never existed.

"Nevertheless, if there is a loss, someone must suffer it, and he must have existence and specific spatial and temporal location even if the loss itself does not. The fact that Beethoven had no children may have been a cause of regret to him, or a sad thing for the world, but it cannot be described as a misfortune for the children that he never had… it cannot be said that not to be born is a misfortune." (p.78)

Third challenge

3. "third type of difficulty concerns the asymmetry…between our attitudes to posthumous and prenatal nonexistence. How can the former be bad if the latter is not?" (p.76)



Lucretius (99-55 BCE)

P1. One's prenatal nonexistence is not bad for the person.

P2. If one's prenatal nonexistence is not bad for the person,

death is not bad for the person.

C. Death is not bad for the person.

Valid or invalid?

No need to memorise the grey parts

(1) Always valid Modus Ponens (affirming the antecedent)

If A, then B
A.
Therefore, B.

(2) Always valid Modus Tollens (denying the consequent)

If A, then B
Not B.
Therefore, Not A.

(3) Always invalid

If A, then B
Not A.
Therefore, Not B.

(4) Always invalid

If A, then B
B.
Therefore, A.

If A, then B
A: antecedent
B: consequent

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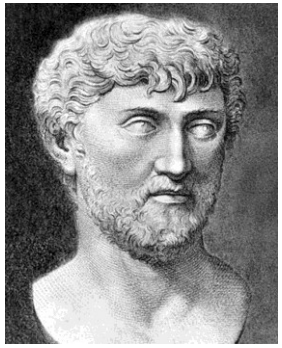

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Which premise should we reject if we don't want to accept the conclusion?

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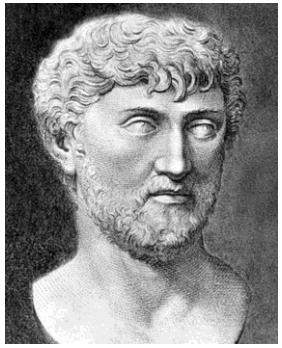

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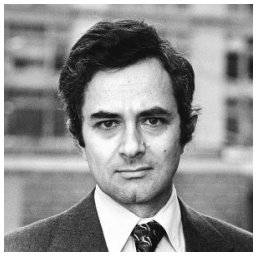
Which premise should we reject if we don't want to accept the conclusion?

P2 is false!



Nagel (1937-)

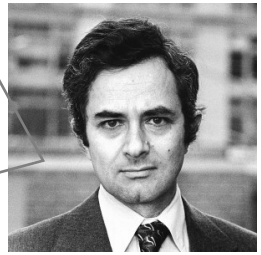
Third challenge

3. "third type of difficulty concerns the asymmetry…between our attitudes to posthumous and prenatal nonexistence. How can the former be bad if the latter is not?" (p.76)

P2. If one's prenatal nonexistence is not bad for the person, death is not bad for the person.

P2 is false because….

"the time after his death is time of which his death deprives him. It is time in which, had he not died then, he would be alive. Therefore any death entails the loss of some life that its victim would have led had he not died at that or any earlier point. We know perfectly well what it would be for him to have had it instead of losing it, and there is no difficulty in identifying the loser. But we cannot say that the time prior to a man's birth is time in which he would have lived had he been born not then but earlier. For aside from the brief margin permitted by premature labor, **he *could* not have been born earlier: anyone born substantially earlier than he was would have been someone else**. Therefore the time prior to his birth is not time in which his subsequent birth prevents him from living. His birth, when it occurs, does not entail the loss to him of any life whatever" (p.79)



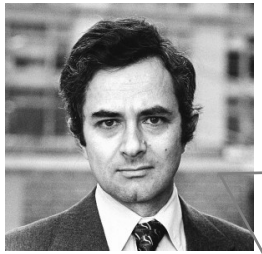
Nagel (1937-)

Nagel later added the following footnote (not relevant to the final exam):

"I confess to being troubled by the above argument…We could imagine discovering that people developed from individual spores that had existed indefinitely far in advance of their birth. In this fantasy, birth never occurs naturally more than a hundred years before the permanent end of the spore's existence. But then we discover a way to trigger the premature hatching of these spores, and people are born who have thousands of years of active life before them. Given such a situation, it would be possible to imagine *oneself* having come into existence thousands of years previously. If we put aside the question whether this would really be the same person, even given the identity of the spore, then the consequence appears to be that a person's birth at a given time could deprive him of many earlier years of possible life. Now while it would be cause for regret that one had been deprived of all those possible years of life by being born too late, the feeling would differ from that which many people have about death. I conclude that something about the future *prospect* of permanent nothingness is not captured by the analysis in terms of denied possibilities…"

“the question remains whether death, no matter when it occurs, can be said to deprive its victim of what is in the relevant sense a possible continuation of life.” (p.80)

Is death bad even when you die at, say, 110?



Nagel (1937-)

"The situation is an ambiguous one. Observed from without, human beings obviously have a natural lifespan and cannot live much longer than a hundred years. A man's sense of his own experience, on the other hand, does not embody this idea of a natural limit. His existence defines for him an essentially open-ended possible future, containing the usual mixture of goods and evils that he has found so tolerable in the past. Having been gratuitously introduced to the world by a collection of natural, historical, and social accidents, he finds himself the subject of a *life*, with an indeterminate and not essentially limited future. Viewed in this way, death, no matter how inevitable, is an abrupt cancellation of indefinitely extensive possible goods. Normality seems to have nothing to do with it, for the fact that we will all inevitably die in a few score years cannot by itself imply that it would not be good to live longer. If there is no limit to the amount of life that it would be good to have, then **it may be that a bad end is in store for us all**." (p.80)

I hope that, until the “bad end” finally arrives,

your life will be as valuable as possible (in your favorite sense of “valuable life”).